mere 50 hectares. So, in terms of sheer scale, the urban landscape of Ashoka's early years was singular. The Pataliputra of his childhood was not just any walled city on the banks of a big river. It was by the standards of the time an enormous sprawl which, by comparison with other Indian urban centres and cities, was colossal.

This sprawling metropolis now formed the political core of a subcontinental empire which, with an emperor residing in it, possessed enormous authority. The king's palace in a city of these dimensions is likely to have been impressive, but Megasthenes does not describe it. The security arrangements of his residence, however, are: Shakespeare's 'uneasy lies the head that wears the crown' could have been said of Ashoka's forefathers instead of Henry IV, for Megasthenes tells us that the king was not meant to sleep in the daytime and by night had constantly to change his 'couch' because he had to safeguard himself against all the people plotting to kill him. For this reason his care was entrusted to women, Megasthenes says—the time lag between the Greeks and us leaving room for doubt about whether he was also being tongue-in-cheek when making the observation. But safety *was* a pressing concern; Ashoka's own grandfather had usurped the crown only a short few years earlier, and we know that some fifty years after Ashoka the crown was again snatched off the Mauryan brow by another usurper. So, every ruling dynast would have had as his first instinct the certainty of being the cynosure within a predatory, treacherous ambience, the daggers barely sheathed round every corner. The king, Megasthenes says, left his palace only on specific occasions: in times of war, when he judged cases in court, when he offered sacrifice, and when he went hunting. The rituals surrounding the hunt as the emperor left the palace are vividly captured in his account, not least because they are so extraordinary, the emperor being surrounded by an immediate ring of female security guards: